

WELCOME TO SOIL FOUNDATION

Nurturing Nature. Empowering Communities.

Who We Are?

SOIL Foundation (Supporting Optimal Improvement of Lives) is an ambitious grassroots Civil Society Organization committed to creating meaningful and sustainable change for people, communities and nature. Established in 2019 in the ecologically sensitive Western Ghats region of Uttara Kannada, Karnataka, SOIL is a registered trust with a strong connection to the region, its communities and the natural ecosystems that sustain them.

Founded by young development professionals with a strong belief in giving back to society, SOIL emerged from a shared commitment to address the ecological and social challenges affecting communities and their surroundings. While rooted in the Western Ghats, our work has grown across Karnataka.

Over the years, SOIL has evolved as a community-driven organisation, bringing together professional expertise, local knowledge and collective action to create solutions that are inclusive, relevant and sustainable. We believe communities are not merely recipients of development, but active partners in shaping the change they wish to see.

At SOIL, we work with communities, not just for them—listening, learning, strengthening local capacities and nurturing locally owned solutions for lasting impact.

Our Story

Having grown up in the Western Ghats, the founders of SOIL Foundation developed a deep connection with its natural environment and the communities that call it home. Over the years, they witnessed the growing pressures on both nature and livelihoods, including deforestation, mining, encroachment, unsustainable forest resource collection and the degradation of natural water bodies.

As development professionals, these experiences strengthened their desire to give back to society and bring their own ideas, experiences and perspectives into action. This aspiration led to the establishment of SOIL Foundation in 2019. What began with a deep connection to the Western Ghats has grown into a broader journey of improving lives, strengthening communities and nurturing a sustainable relationship between people and nature.

Our Vision:

“A world where every life flourishes in harmony with nature”.

Our Mission:

“Our mission is to foster development by protecting the environment, promoting ecological balance, advancing education and health, empowering women and supporting tribal development, thereby building a sustainable and equitable future for all”.

Our values:

- a. Grassroot action
- b. Collaboration

- c. Enabling
- d. Professionalism
- e. Accountability
- f. Sustainability

Our Impact

- 18,500 Families
- 415 + villages
- 11 projects
- 10 districts
- 2 states

Our Team

SOIL Foundation is a young and growing Civil Society Organization led by a team of development professionals with 8–10 years of experience across government and non-government sectors. Our team brings diverse expertise in community mobilization, stakeholder engagement and communication, community institution building, livelihoods promotion, programme implementation, collaboration and networking.

Grounded in grassroots realities and driven by a commitment to meaningful change, we bring together experience, local knowledge and innovative approaches to design and implement solutions that are inclusive, practical and sustainable.

Young in our journey. Experienced in our approach. Committed to lasting impact.

Our Areas of Impact

1. Ecological Conservation

SOIL works to protect and restore ecosystems across Karnataka, with a strong focus on conserving the ecologically rich Western Ghats. Our initiatives include conservation of natural and wild water bodies, promotion of organic and sustainable farming practices, responsible forest management and community-led efforts to protect and nurture local ecosystems.

Key Initiatives:

a. Green School Initiative – Planting the Fruitful Future

“From digging the pit to enjoying the fruit — learning, nurturing and growing with nature.”

The Green School Initiative nurtures environmental awareness among children by taking them beyond one-day plantation drives and involving them in the complete journey of fruit-bearing and horticultural trees—from digging the pit to planting, nurturing and enjoying the fruit.

By creating greener school spaces and encouraging hands-on learning, the initiative helps children develop a deeper understanding of trees, soil, biodiversity and ecological balance, while building a lasting connection with nature.

b. Nursery Development Programme

“Growing livelihoods while nurturing nature”

SOIL Foundation promotes nature-based livelihoods through nursery development, engaging women SHG members in learning practical skills related to raising and caring for plants. The initiative encourages community-based plant nurseries as a sustainable livelihood opportunity while contributing to greener surroundings and ecological well-being.

By connecting livelihood opportunities with environmental action, the programme demonstrates how protecting and nurturing nature can also create pathways for community empowerment and sustainable incomes.

c. Climate Literacy Programme

“Learn. Act. Lead. — empowering young climate leaders for a sustainable future.”

The Climate Literacy Programme equips young people aged 10–21 with the knowledge, skills and confidence to understand climate change and become active contributors to environmental solutions.

Primarily implemented through schools and colleges, the programme uses interactive learning, hands-on climate action and community engagement to encourage youth to explore local environmental challenges, adopt sustainable practices and inspire positive change. It also brings together government departments, educational institutions, educators, local communities and other stakeholders to strengthen climate awareness and collective action.

2. Women Empowerment

SOIL supports women to become confident, skilled and economically independent through entrepreneurship development, capacity building and sustainable livelihood opportunities. Our initiatives also promote health and well-being while strengthening women's leadership and participation in community development.

Key initiatives:

a. Menstrual Hygiene Management Awareness Programme

“Empowering girls with knowledge, dignity and the confidence to learn and thrive.”

Menstrual Hygiene Management (MHM) is one of SOIL Foundation's signature initiatives under Women Empowerment, supporting adolescent girls with awareness, healthy menstrual practices and the confidence to manage their periods with dignity.

Through awareness sessions, practical guidance, healthcare linkages and access to sanitary products, SOIL works with schools, healthcare institutions, ASHA workers and local doctors to create a supportive environment for girls. The initiative also seeks to reduce menstruation-related barriers to school attendance and participation, enabling girls to continue their education with confidence.

b. Women Entrepreneurship Development Programme

“Empowering women to turn skills and ideas into sustainable livelihoods”

SOIL Foundation empowers women SHG members to explore and strengthen entrepreneurship and income-generating opportunities through practical learning and capacity building. The programme supports women interested in starting or strengthening small enterprises such as petty shops, food processing, pickle and papad making, tailoring and other home-based businesses.

By integrating entrepreneurship development with financial and digital literacy, the initiative helps women build confidence, manage their finances, use digital tools and make informed decisions to strengthen their livelihoods.

c. Tailoring & Embroidery Training Programme

“Skills that create opportunities, confidence and livelihoods.”

SOIL Foundation supports women SHG members with practical skills and livelihood opportunities through tailoring and embroidery training. The programme integrates vocational skills with financial and digital literacy, helping women build confidence, manage their finances and explore sustainable income-generating opportunities.

At the completion of the training, participants receive essential tailoring and embroidery equipment to put their newly acquired skills into practice and take their first steps towards independent livelihoods.

d. Financial & Digital Literacy Programme

“Building financial confidence, strengthening digital skills and enabling informed choices.”

Financial & Digital Literacy is a key initiative of SOIL Foundation that strengthens financial knowledge, digital confidence and informed decision-making among women SHG members, rural women entrepreneurs and young people.

Through community-based awareness programmes, practical learning sessions and expert-led training, participants gain the knowledge and skills to make informed financial decisions, use formal and digital financial services safely, manage household and livelihood finances, and recognise common financial and digital risks.

e. Kitchen Garden Initiative

“Growing food, strengthening families and nurturing sustainable household practices”

During the COVID-19 pandemic, SOIL Foundation supported women SHG member families across six districts of Karnataka with kitchen garden kits and practical guidance on household gardening.

The initiative encouraged families to grow fresh vegetables in available spaces, strengthening household food and nutrition security while promoting low-cost and sustainable food-growing practices. It also encouraged women to take an active role in managing household nutrition and resources.

3. Education

SOIL Foundation promotes lifelong learning and capacity building for children, youth and adults, recognising education as a pathway to greater awareness, confidence and opportunity. Our work includes academic support, digital literacy, career guidance, improved learning environments and capacity building for community leaders, helping individuals and communities develop the knowledge and skills needed to make informed decisions and contribute to positive change.

Key Initiatives:

a. Career Guidance & Mentorship

“Helping young minds discover possibilities and build pathways to a confident future.”

SOIL Foundation provides career guidance and mentorship to young people, helping them understand their interests, explore educational and career pathways, and make informed choices about their future. Through interactive sessions and exposure to diverse opportunities, we encourage young people to build confidence, clarity and aspirations for their personal and professional journeys.

b. Sarpanch Samvad – Digital Capacity Building

“Enabling grassroots leaders with digital knowledge for learning, collaboration and better community engagement.”

SOIL Foundation, in collaboration with ISRA – Institute of Social Responsibility and Accountability, supported the digital onboarding and capacity building of elected Panchayat Presidents across Karnataka and Maharashtra on Sarpanch Samvad, a mobile application developed by the Quality Council of India (QCI).

The initiative enabled Panchayat leaders to connect, exchange experiences, learn from local development initiatives and share good practices, while SOIL supported digital onboarding, application orientation and capacity building for effective use of the platform.

4. Tribal Development

SOIL Foundation is committed to supporting the holistic development of tribal communities by strengthening traditional knowledge, cultural heritage, skills and sustainable livelihoods. We aim to promote social inclusion and improve access to essential opportunities and services, enabling tribal families to pursue greater economic independence, dignity and equal opportunities.

Our Esteemed Partners:

Resources:

Annual reports

Financial reports

Social media

Media Coverage

Support Us

Change becomes meaningful when we choose to be part of it.

At SOIL Foundation, we believe lasting change grows when people, communities and nature come together. Your support can help us expand our work in ecological conservation, women empowerment, education and Tribal development.

Whether through financial support, partnerships, expertise, resources or volunteering, you can be part of creating a more sustainable, inclusive and equitable future.

Stand with us. Be part of the change.

Other headings required

Glimpses

Facebook & linden icons